FREE POP-UP CHESS CLUB KIT

Welcome to the Board

Prop this poster up where everyone can see it. It answers the two questions every new face asks: *what is this?* and *how do I behave?*

What happens here: friendly chess at gentle speeds. New to chess or returning after twenty years — both counts. Tell the host you're new and you'll be handed the **Teaching Ladder**: eight tiny games, one idea each, ending with a full real game. No rating, no signup, no pieces needed — we bring the board.

The house rules of the table

1. **Touch move, gently.** If you touch a piece on purpose, it moves. On your very first night, take-backs are on the house — don't make a habit of them.
2. **Let them think.** No commenting on a game in progress. The celebrating, the groaning, and the "why did you do THAT?" all come after the handshake.
3. **Clock courtesy.** Press the clock with the same hand that moves. Beginners play without a clock or with lots of time — ask, don't assume.
4. **Say "check" once.** Say it the first time, point at the king if they seem unsure. The thirty-fifth reminder is on them.
5. **Resign like a grown-up.** Tilted the rook? Tip your king and shake hands. Losing fast is a skill; practice it here where it's safe.
6. **Be kind to beginners.** Every strong player here was once mated in four moves. Win gently, teach softly, and never keep score out loud.
7. **Reset the board together.** Pieces back on their squares, box closed, table wiped. The next group deserves a clean board.

Quick answers for the shy

- ♟ **"I only know how the pieces move."** Perfect. That is genuinely all you need for Game 1 of the ladder.
- ♟ **"I haven't played in years."** Welcome back. Start at Game 5 or 6 and shake the rust off.
- ♟ **"Do I have to play the winner?"** No. The host pairs everyone, beginners against beginners first.
- ♟ **"Can I watch before playing?"** Yes. Watching from the elbow is a legitimate chess activity.
- ♟ **"Is losing embarrassing?"** Losing is the game. Nobody here has won every game they've played. Nobody.

One idea per game

We teach the slow way: each game in the Teaching Ladder has exactly **one job** — how pawns march, where kings may stand, when to castle, what checkmate really means. Play the game, learn the idea, collect the stamp in your Progress Passport, and go home one chess trick richer.

When you're ready for more

Ask the host for the sibling freebies: a take-home comeback guide for adult beginners, a puzzle-drill site for your browser, and printable scoresheets. All free, no signups, no ads — same friendly voice.